as competition for patronage.’[9] The Buddhists, likely on the defensive, resorted to this dramatic imagery to assert their religion’s superiority to ambivalent folk.

While Nalanda was the preeminent centre of Buddhist learning in India during most of its existence, it was also part of a network of monasteries in the region, including Uddandapura, 12 km north of Nalanda; Yashovarmapura, 22 km east; and Tiladhaka, 33 km northwest. Further afield were Vikramashila in Bihar, and Somapura and Jaggadala in Bangladesh. Most of these sites have been at least partially excavated. What collaborations and rivalries did these monasteries have with each other? We don’t know a whole lot but we can guess a few reasons. Historian Sukumar Dutt has argued that the Palas, the last major patrons of Buddhism in India, had started shifting funds away from Mahayana-centric Nalanda to Vajrayana-centric monasteries like Vikramashila and Somapura, which they had founded. In large measure, this shift was a response to the rising popular appeal of Vajrayana, or Tantric Buddhism—a mystical, ascetic, syncretic, magic-infused and community-involved sect of Buddhism.[10]

I spend half a day at the Nalanda site museum before returning to Bihar Sharif. I wander its streets, picking on a roasted corn on the cob daubed with salt and lemon. Buffaloes in narrow lanes vie for space with people and noisy, smoke-belching vehicles, including ornately decorated autos. With over three lakh people, minimal town planning and hardly any municipal services, Bihar Sharif is about as unlovely as it gets: open drains, fetid smells, rotting piles of refuse and hot steaming discs of bovine poo. I see no parks, pavements or public squares. The exteriors of most buildings have been left unplastered and unpainted, accentuating the town’s shabby look. I wonder how all this deflating ugliness might impact the psyches of local men and women.

Amid all the chaos are vendors with cartfuls of juicy malda mangoes and fresh vegetables. Congested market lanes throng with people, suggesting enterprise and nascent consumerism. I see two old-fashioned single-screen cinema halls still going strong and Hindi film posters stuck on walls all over town. A Big Bazaar store has opened too. Next to it is perhaps the first pizzeria in town, with a bubbly young woman at the counter trying out her English with customers. Countless ads for coaching classes promise